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A study of high blood pressure treatments found certain meditation techniques and the most commonly prescribed drugs are equally effective if the selected treatment is followed as directed over the long term. Half the patients given drugs soon stop taking them regularly, whereas 80 percent of the study's participants who were taught meditation techniques were still regularly using them five years later. Therefore, the meditation treatment is the one likely to produce the best results.

Which of the following, if true, most seriously weakens the argument?

A. People who have high blood pressure are usually advised by their physicians to make changes in diet that have been found in many cases to reduce the severity of the condition.

B. The participants in the study were selected in part on the basis of their willingness to use meditation techniques.

C. Meditation techniques can reduce the blood pressure of people who do not suffer from high blood pressure.

D. Some of the participants in the study whose high blood pressure was controlled through meditation techniques were physicians.

E. Many people with dangerously high blood pressure are unaware of their condition.

Argument Evaluation

Situation In a study of treatments for high blood pressure, meditation and medication both worked equally well at managing the condition as long as patients adhered to their treatment plan. However, patients prescribed meditation were significantly more likely to continue the treatment than patients prescribed medication, so the author concludes that meditation is likely to be more effective.

Reasoning *What factor would undermine the contention that meditation is the better treatment for high blood pressure?* Since the argument that meditation is better than medication depends on study participants' good adherence to a program of meditation, the argument would be weakened by evidence that the general population might not be as likely to continue meditating as the participants were.

A. The fact that high blood pressure patients are usually advised to change their diets has no bearing on the efficacy of other methods of managing high blood pressure.

B. **Correct.** If study participants were selected partly on the basis of their willingness to practice meditation, then those participants might have better adherence to a meditation program than the general population, who might well be less willing or less able to meditate consistently over long periods of time. Such a discrepancy between the study participants and other patients would seriously undermine the argument that meditation will work better than medication since that argument depends entirely on the contention that more patients will continue with meditation than with medication.

C. The fact that meditation techniques can lower blood pressure in people whose levels are healthy does not undermine the argument that meditation is the best treatment for those whose levels are unhealthy.

D. The fact that some of the participants who benefited from meditation were physicians does not undermine the argument that meditation will be the best treatment for blood pressure patients who may not be physicians. It does not, by itself, indicate the sample studied was unrepresentative.

E. People with high blood pressure being unaware of their condition reduces the likelihood that they will be treated, but it does not undermine the argument that one treatment is better than another.

The correct answer is B.

•

Many industrialized nations are trying to reduce atmospheric concentrations of carbon dioxide, a gas released by the burning of fossil fuels. One proposal is to replace conventional cement, which is made with calcium carbonate, by a new "eco-cement." This new cement, made with magnesium carbonate, absorbs large amounts of carbon dioxide when exposed to the atmosphere. Therefore, using eco-cement for new concrete building projects will significantly help reduce atmospheric concentrations of carbon dioxide.

Which of the following, if true, most strengthens the argument?

A. The cost of magnesium carbonate, currently greater than the cost of calcium carbonate, probably will fall as more magnesium carbonate is used in cement manufacture.

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more magnesium carbonate is used in cement manufacture.

B. Eco-cement is strengthened when absorbed carbon dioxide reacts with the cement.

C. Before the development of eco-cement, magnesium-based cement was considered too susceptible to water erosion to be of practical use.

D. The manufacture of eco-cement uses considerably less fossil fuel per unit of cement than the manufacture of conventional cement does.

E. Most building-industry groups are unaware of the development or availability of eco-cement.

Argument Evaluation

Situation Many nations are trying to reduce atmospheric concentrations of carbon dioxide. One proposed method is to use a new type of "eco-cement" that absorbs carbon dioxide from air.

Reasoning *What evidence, combined with the cited facts, would most support the prediction that using eco-cement will significantly help reduce atmospheric concentrations of carbon dioxide?* The prediction assumes that the use of eco-cement would be an effective way to reduce carbon dioxide levels. Any evidence supporting this assumption will support the prediction.

A. Since eco-cement uses magnesium carbonate, the prediction that magnesium carbonate prices will fall suggests that a potential financial barrier to widespread eco-cement use will diminish. However, those prices may not fall enough to make eco-cement cost-competitive with regular cement.

B. Even if absorbed carbon dioxide strengthens eco-cement, the strengthened eco-cement might still be much weaker than regular cement and thus might never become widely used, in which case it will not significantly help reduce atmospheric concentrations of carbon dioxide.

C. Even if eco-cement is less susceptible to water erosion than earlier forms of magnesium-based cement were, it might still be much more susceptible to water erosion than regular cement is, and thus might never become widely used.

D. **Correct.** This suggests that manufacturing eco-cement produces much less carbon dioxide than manufacturing regular cement does, so it supports the claim that widespread use of eco-cement would be an effective way to reduce carbon dioxide levels.

E. If anything, this lack of awareness makes it less likely that eco-cement will become widely used, which in turn makes it less likely that eco-cement will significantly help reduce atmospheric concentrations of carbon dioxide.

The correct answer is D.

•

Professor: A marine biologist argues that transmission of sea lice from farm salmon to wild salmon is unlikely in the Broughton Archipelago, British Columbia, citing numerous studies suggesting that salinities less than 30 parts per thousand are unfavorable to sea-lice survival. The biologist concludes that the archipelago's 25–30 parts per thousand salinity range between March and June, the critical period for wild salmon migration, tends to suppress sea-lice proliferation. But a review of the literature shows that salinities of 25–30 parts per thousand in combination with British Columbia's cool spring temperatures favor the flourishing of sea lice.

In this passage, the professor attempts to undermine the biologist's argument by

A. pointing out that a condition claimed to be necessary for sea-lice survival is not sufficient for it

B. citing studies that suggest that salinity levels were not measured reliably

C. claiming that there is evidence showing that one of its premises is false

D. questioning the reliability of the biologist's scientific sources

E. showing that its conclusion is inconsistent with its premises

Argument Evaluation

Situation A professor gives us information about one biologist's opinion, based on numerous studies, about the low probability of sea-lice transmission from farm salmon to wild salmon in the Broughton Archipelago. The biologist thinks salinities less than 30 parts per thousand (ppt) would make such

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Archipelago. The biologist thinks salinities less than 30 parts per thousand (ppt) would make such transmission unlikely; in the archipelago, the salinity is 25–30 ppt between March and June, the period when wild salmon migration occurs. However, the professor challenges the biologist's view, maintaining, based on a literature review, that cool spring temperatures in the archipelago, combined with the lower salinity, do favor the flourishing of sea lice.

Reasoning *In what way does the professor attempt to undermine the biologist's argument?* The professor points out that a premise used by the biologist—that the low spring salinities in the archipelago when the wild salmon migrate suppress sea-lice proliferation—is not correct. The professor claims the academic literature reveals that two conditions—the 25–30 ppt salinities combined with the cool spring temperatures—would be jointly sufficient for the flourishing of sea lice.

A. This does not accurately describe the professor's technique. In effect, the professor points out that salinities of 30 ppt or more are NOT necessary for sea-lice survival; lower salinities combined with lower temperatures are sufficient to enable sea-lice survival.

B. The professor cites no studies that suggest unreliable measurement of salinity levels.

C. Correct. As explained in the Reasoning section above, the professor appeals to evidence from the literature to show that one of the biologist's premises is false.

D. The professor primarily questions the conclusion that the biologist draws from the sources; the professor does not question the reliability of the sources.

E. The professor undermines the biologist's argument by claiming that one of its premises is false and thus that the conclusion might not follow. The professor does not claim that if the premises were true, the conclusion would have to be false.

The correct answer is C.

•

Advertisement: When your car's engine is running at its normal operating temperature, any major brand of motor oil will protect it about as well as Tuff does. When the engine is cold, it is a different story: Tuff motor oil flows better at lower temperatures than its major competitors do. So, if you want your car's engine to have maximum protection, you should use Tuff.

Which of the following, if true, most strengthens the argument in the advertisement?

A. Tuff motor oil provides above-average protection for engines that happen to overheat.

B. Tuff motor oil is periodically supplied free of charge to automobile manufacturers to use in factory-new cars.

C. Tuff motor oil's share of the engine oil market peaked three years ago.

D. Tuff motor oil, like any motor oil, is thicker and flows less freely at cold temperatures than at hot temperatures.

E. Tuff motor oil is manufactured at only one refinery and shipped from there to all markets.

Argument Evaluation

Situation An advertisement argues that since Tuff motor oil flows better than its major competitors at low temperatures and works about as well as they do at normal temperatures, it provides *maximum protection* for car engines.

Reasoning *What additional evidence would suggest that Tuff motor oil provides the best available protection for car engines?* The argument requires the assumptions that no type of motor oil other than the "major brands" provides superior protection, that flowing better at lower temperatures ensures superior protection at those temperatures, and that Tuff protects car engines at least as well as its competitors do at above-normal temperatures. Any evidence supporting any of these assumptions would strengthen the argument.

A. **Correct.** If Tuff provides above-average protection when engines overheat, in addition to the solid protection it provides at normal and low temperatures, it may well provide the best available protection overall.

B. The company that makes Tuff might give automobile manufacturers free motor oil as a promotional gimmick even if Tuff is an inferior product.

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even if Tuff is an inferior product.

C. Tuff's sales might have declined over the past three years because consumers have realized that Tuff is an inferior product.

D. The similar responses of Tuff and other motor oils to temperature changes do not suggest that Tuff provides better protection overall than those other motor oils do.

E. Even if Tuff is manufactured at only one refinery, it may still be an inferior product.

The correct answer is A.

•

Linguist: In English, the past is described as "behind" and the future "ahead," whereas in Aymara, the past is "ahead" and the future "behind." Research indicates that English speakers sway backward when discussing the past and forward when discussing the future. Conversely, Aymara speakers gesture forward with their hands when discussing the past and backward when discussing the future. These bodily movements, therefore, suggest that the language one speaks affects how one mentally visualizes time.

The linguist's reasoning depends on assuming which of the following?

A. At least some Aymara speakers sway forward when discussing the past and backward when discussing the future.

B. Most people mentally visualize time as running either forward or backward.

C. Not all English and Aymara speakers tend to sway or gesture forward or backward when discussing the present.

D. How people move when discussing the future correlates to some extent with how they mentally visualize time.

E. The researchers also examined the movements of at least some speakers of languages other than English and Aymara discussing the past and the future.

Argument Construction

Situation A linguist argues that the language one speaks affects how one mentally visualizes time. The linguist's argument is based on the fact that English speakers, who refer to the past as "behind" and the future as "ahead," display backward and forward bodily movements when speaking of the past and the future, while speakers of Aymara, who refer to the past as "ahead" and the future as "behind," display correspondingly different body movements.

Reasoning *What must be true if we are to accept the linguist's conclusion from the given information that the language one speaks affects how one mentally visualizes time?* The linguist's evidence will support the conclusion only if there is some correlation between people's bodily movements and how they mentally visualize time. So, the linguist's reasoning requires an assumption to that effect.

A. The linguist's reasoning is based on the differences in bodily movements discussed in the argument—that is, that Aymara speakers gesture in certain ways and that English speakers sway in certain ways; thus, the linguist's reasoning does not require that Aymara speakers sway in any way whatsoever when they discuss the past or future.

B. The linguist's reasoning is based only on speakers of English and Aymara, so no claim related to speakers of other languages—who make up a majority of people—is required.

C. The linguist's argument would actually be stronger if all English and Aymara speakers sway or gesture in the ways discussed, so the argument certainly does not depend on assuming that not all such speakers sway or gesture in these ways.

D. **Correct.** The fact that English and Aymara speakers sway or gesture in the ways described would be irrelevant to the linguist's conclusion if how people move when discussing the future does not correlate at least to some extent with how they visualize time.

E. It might be helpful to the linguist's argument to examine the movements of speakers of other languages when they discuss the past and the future, but the linguist's argument does not require this.

The correct answer is D.

•

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The Testament of William Thorpe was published around 1530 as an appendix to Thorpe's longer *Examination*. Many scholars, however, doubt the attribution of the *Testament* to Thorpe because, whereas the *Examination* is dated 1406, the *Testament* is dated 1460. One scholar has recently argued that the 1460 date be amended to 1409, based on the observation that when these numbers are expressed as Roman numerals, MCCCCLX and MCCCCIX, it becomes easy to see how the dates might have become confused through scribal error.

Which of the following, if true, would most support the scholar's hypothesis concerning the date of the *Testament*?

A. The sole evidence that historians have had that William Thorpe died no earlier than 1460 was the presumed date of publication of the *Testament*.

B. In the preface to the 1530 publication, the editor attributes both works to William Thorpe.

C. Few writers in fifteenth-century England marked dates in their works using only Roman numerals.

D. The *Testament* alludes to a date, "Friday, September 20," as apparently contemporaneous with the writing of the *Testament*, and September 20 fell on a Friday in 1409 but not in 1460.

E. The *Testament* contains few references to historical events that occurred later than 1406.

Argument Construction

Situation *The Testament of William Thorpe*, dated 1460, was published around 1530 as an appendix to Thorpe's *Examination*, dated 1406. But when expressed in Roman numerals, 1460 could easily be confused with 1409.

Reasoning *Given the facts cited, what would provide additional evidence that Thorpe's* Testament *dates from 1409 rather than 1460?* The scholar's hypothesis that the work dates from 1409 is based on the observation that in Roman numerals, 1409 might easily have been improperly transcribed as 1460. What evidence would support this hypothesis? Any independent evidence that 1409 is a more likely date for the *Testament* than 1460 would certainly help. For instance, if some event or date that occurred in 1409 but not in 1460 is referred to in the *Testament* as being recent or contemporaneous, this would lend significant support to the hypothesis. For instance, if the *Testament* indicated that some day of the month had just fallen on a given day of the week, and that date fell on that day in 1409 but not in 1460, this would support the hypothesis significantly.

A. Suppose there is no reason to think that Thorpe was still alive in 1460 other than the presumption that the *Testament* was published in that year. That gives us no more reason to accept the scholar's hypothesis about a scribal error in reporting the date than to accept the other scholars' hypothesis that the *Testament* is improperly ascribed to Thorpe. Furthermore, it provides very little reason to support either of these hypotheses, because the mere lack of evidence, other than the purported 1460 date of creation, that Thorpe died no earlier than 1460 does not provide us with any evidence that he *did* die earlier than 1460.

B. The editor of the 1530 publication could easily have been mistaken about the authorship of one or both works. And even if the editor were correct, Thorpe might have lived long enough to write one work in 1406 and the other in 1460.

C. This would cast doubt on the scholar's argument by providing evidence that the original manuscripts were not dated only in Roman numerals.

D. **Correct.** As explained in the Reasoning section above, this provides strong evidence directly supporting the hypothesis that the *Testament* dates from 1409 specifically.

E. Even if the *Testament* contained only one reference to a historical event that occurred later than 1406 (for example, one event in 1459), that reference alone could provide strong evidence that the work dates from 1460 rather than 1409.

The correct answer is D.

•

A prominent investor who holds a large stake in the Burton Tool Company has recently claimed that the company is mismanaged, citing as evidence the company's failure to slow down production in response to a recent rise in its inventory of finished products. It is doubtful whether an investor's sniping at management can ever be anything other than counterproductive, but in this case, it is clearly not justified. It is true that **an increased inventory of finished products often indicates that production is outstripping demand**, but in Burton's case it indicates no such thing

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products often indicates that production is outstripping demand, but in Burton's case it indicates no such thing. Rather, **the increase in inventory is entirely attributable to products that have already been assigned to orders received from customers.**

In the argument given, the two **boldfaced** portions play which of the following roles?

A. The first states a generalization that underlies the position that the argument as a whole opposes; the second provides evidence to show that the generalization does not apply in the case at issue.

B. The first states a generalization that underlies the position that the argument as a whole opposes; the second clarifies the meaning of a specific phrase as it is used in that generalization.

C. The first provides evidence to support the conclusion of the argument as a whole; the second is evidence that has been used to support the position that the argument as a whole opposes.

D. The first provides evidence to support the conclusion of the argument as a whole; the second states that conclusion.

E. The first and the second each provide evidence against the position that the argument as a whole opposes.

Argument Construction

Situation An investor has criticized a company, based on the company's recent increase in inventory and on its not decreasing production as a result of this increase.

Reasoning *What roles do the two **boldfaced** statements play in the argument?* The argument suggests that the investor's criticism is based on a principle that increased inventory of finished products often indicates that production is faster than it should be, given the existing demand for a company's products. However, the argument then states that the increase in inventory at the company in question is *entirely attributable* to existing orders of products. The argument thus suggests that the investor's criticism is misplaced, based on a suggestion as to (1) a principle that the investor could be using to support her argument and (2) an explanation as to why the principle does not apply to the company. The two **boldfaced** portions state these respective elements.

A. **Correct.** The first **boldfaced** portion states the principle that may provide the basis of the investor's criticism, which the argument as a whole opposes. The second **boldfaced** portion is a statement that, if true, shows the generalization would not apply to the company in question.

B. This option correctly describes the first of the **boldfaced** portions. However, rather than clarifying an aspect of the meaning of the first generalization, the second **boldfaced** portion indicates why the first generalization may not apply to the company.

C. This option incorrectly describes both of the **boldfaced** portions. The first **boldfaced** portion states a general principle that could support the position that the argument *opposes*. The second **boldfaced** portion then criticizes the application of the principle.

D. Because the second **boldfaced** portion describes a fundamental premise rather than the conclusion, the description in this option of the second **boldfaced** portion is incorrect.

E. If we think of an argument as a set of statements that are meant to support, or provide evidence for, a conclusion, then, because the **boldfaced** statements are indeed part of the argument, they may be seen as providing evidence for the position the argument opposes. However, a description of the roles of the **boldfaced** statements in this argument would need to provide more detail, such as what option A provides.

The correct answer is A.

•

Kate: The recent decline in numbers of the Tennessee warbler, a North American songbird that migrates each fall to coffee plantations in South America, is due to the elimination of the dense tree cover that formerly was a feature of most South American coffee plantations.

Scott: The population of the spruce budworm, the warbler's favorite prey in North America, has been dropping. This is a more likely explanation of the warbler's decline.

Which of the following, if true, most seriously calls Scott's hypothesis into question?

A. The numbers of the Baltimore oriole, a songbird that does not eat budworms but is as dependent on South

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A. The numbers of the Baltimore oriole, a songbird that does not eat budworms but is as dependent on South American coffee plantations as the Tennessee warbler, are declining.

B. The spruce budworm population has dropped because of a disease that can infect budworms but not Tennessee warblers.

C. The drop in the population of the spruce budworm is expected to be only temporary.

D. Many Tennessee warblers have begun migrating in the fall to places other than traditional coffee plantations.

E. Although many North American songbirds have declined in numbers, no other species has experienced as great a decline as the Tennessee warbler.

Argument Evaluation

Situation Scott and Kate are arguing about the reason for declining numbers of Tennessee warblers. Kate believes that loss of habitat, specifically tree cover in South American coffee plantations, is to blame. Scott, by contrast, posits that the declining population of North American spruce budworms, which the warblers eat, is more likely to be to blame.

Reasoning *What would undermine the argument that declining numbers of budworms have caused declining numbers of Tennessee warblers?* Scott and Kate have identified two possible causes for the warblers' decline: loss of habitat and loss of prey. If other species that depend on the same habitat but not on the same prey are shown to be suffering similar decline, that fact would tend to support Kate's argument that habitat loss is the main issue and to undermine Scott's argument that prey loss is the main issue.

A. **Correct.** If the Baltimore oriole, a species that relies on the same habitat as the Tennessee warbler but not on the same food sources, is also declining, then that fact would call into question Scott's hypothesis that not habitat loss but rather loss of food, specifically spruce budworm, is probably the reason for the warblers' decline.

B. The reason behind declining numbers of spruce budworm does not affect the question of whether fewer budworms are the main cause of fewer warblers.

C. The fact that budworm populations are expected to rebound has no bearing on whether or not budworm population decline is the main cause of warbler population decline.

D. If Tennessee warblers have begun migrating to habitats other than South American coffee plantations, then if the new habitats lack the dense tree cover traditional in South American coffee plantations, that fact would tend to undermine Kate's argument, not Scott's.

E. The greater decline of Tennessee warbler populations relative to those of other songbirds has no direct bearing on the cause of the warblers' decline.

The correct answer is A.

•

Advertising by mail has become much less effective, with fewer consumers responding. Because consumers are increasingly overwhelmed by the sheer amount of junk mail they receive, most discard almost all offers without considering them. Thus, an effective way for corporations to improve response rates would be to more carefully target the individuals to whom they mail advertising, thereby cutting down on the amount of junk mail each consumer receives.

Which of the following, if true, would most support the recommendation above?

A. There are cost-effective means by which corporations that currently advertise by mail could improve response rates.

B. Many successful corporations are already carefully targeting the individuals to whom they mail advertising.

C. Any consumer who, immediately after receiving an advertisement by mail, merely glances at it is very likely to discard it.

D. Improvements in the quality of the advertising materials used in mail that is carefully targeted to individuals can improve the response rate for such mail.

E. Response rates to carefully targeted advertisements by mail are considerably higher, on average, than response rates to most other forms of advertising.

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Evaluation of a Plan

Situation Advertising by mail has become less effective because consumers overwhelmed with the amount of junk mail they receive discard almost all of it without considering it.

Reasoning *What would most help to support the claim that making mail advertising more carefully targeted would improve response rates?* The passage recommends targeted advertising, reasoning that since targeted advertising would reduce the total amount of junk mail consumers receive, it would generate higher response rates. Any additional evidence for the claim that carefully targeted advertising would improve response rates would support this recommendation.

A. Even if targeted advertising and every other means of improving response rates were too expensive to be cost-effective, targeted advertising could still be effective for any corporation willing to pay the expense.

B. If many corporations already mail targeted advertising, and mail advertising is nonetheless yielding declining response rates, that suggests that targeted mail is an ineffective way to increase response rates.

C. This could be equally true for targeted and untargeted mail advertising, so it does not suggest that the former is more effective.

D. The question under consideration is whether more carefully targeted mail advertising would in itself increase response rates, not whether higher quality advertising would do so.

E. **Correct.** This provides some evidence that carefully targeted mail advertising is associated with higher response rates than untargeted mail advertising is, and therefore that targeting mail advertising more carefully would improve response rates.

The correct answer is E.

•

Petrochemical industry officials have said that the extreme pressure exerted on plant managers during the last five years to improve profits by cutting costs has done nothing to impair the industry's ability to operate safely. However, environmentalists contend that the recent rash of serious oil spills and accidents at petrochemical plants is traceable to cost-cutting measures.

Which of the following, if true, would provide the strongest support for the position held by industry officials?

A. The petrochemical industry benefits if accidents do not occur, since accidents involve risk of employee injury as well as loss of equipment and product.

B. Petrochemical industry unions recently demanded that additional money be spent on safety and environmental protection measures, but the unions readily abandoned those demands in exchange for job security.

C. Despite major cutbacks in most other areas of operation, the petrochemical industry has devoted more of its resources to environmental and safety measures in the last five years than in the preceding five years.

D. There is evidence that the most damaging of the recent oil spills would have been prevented had cost-cutting measures not been instituted.

E. Both the large fines and the adverse publicity generated by the most recent oil spill have prompted the petrochemical industry to increase the resources devoted to oil-spill prevention.

Argument Evaluation

Situation Petrochemical industry officials claim that pressure on plant managers to cut costs over the past five years has not made the industry's operations any less safe. Environmentalists claim that recent oil spills and accidents show otherwise.

Reasoning *What evidence would most strongly suggest that the cost-cutting pressure was not responsible for the recent rash of oil spills and accidents?* Evidence that the plant managers did not cut costs in any specific ways likely to have increased the likelihood of oil spills and accidents would support the industry officials' position that the cost-cutting pressure has not made petrochemical operations any less safe.

A. Even if the petrochemical industry has good reasons to try to prevent accidents, the recent rash of serious

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A. Even if the petrochemical industry has good reasons to try to prevent accidents, the recent rash of serious accidents suggests that it is failing to do so and that the cost-cutting pressure might be responsible.

B. This suggests that the unions, whose members could directly observe the cost-cutting pressure's effects, share the environmentalists' belief that this pressure contributed to the oil spills and accidents. Because the unions abandoned their demands, their concerns probably have not been addressed.

C. **Correct.** This suggests that, as the industry officials claim, the cost-cutting pressure has not in itself reduced the industry's effectiveness at preventing oil spills and accidents. Thus, it suggests that other factors are probably responsible for the recent problems.

D. This clearly suggests that the cost-cutting measures have indeed caused the industry to operate less safely, as the environmentalists claim.

E. Although this suggests that the industry is now trying to address the recent problems, the cost-cutting measures might nonetheless have caused all those problems.

The correct answer is C.

•

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